

Photographs by MANEESH AGARWAL



THE SCENT OF SUCCESS



PLACE FOR PERFUME KANNAUJ, UTTAR PRADESH

THE PERFUMES OF KANNAUJ HAVE THEIR ROOTS IN THE BATH TUB OF QUEEN NOORJAHAN.

What Grasse is to France, Kannauj is to India—home of the best natural *attar* (perfume). Just as Grasse in southern France emerged as a centre for perfumes because of King Louis XIV's passion for scents, the *attar* of Kannauj has its roots in the bath tub of empress Noorjahan. As the story goes, crushed rose petals used to be sprinkled in her tub hours before she used to take her bath. One day, she noticed an oily substance floating on the surface of water. *Rooh gulab* was discovered in that eureka moment, and *attar* was born. Kannauj, near Kanpur, was once the capital of emperor Harshavardhan's kingdom and due to its rich heritage, became the favourite place for Noorjahan's consort Jahangir to experiment with his queen's passion. In the 'Perfume City' of India, there are 250 attar-producing units now, including 12 which export to the Middle-East. A majority of the population is involved in the industry in one form or the other and it is the traditional method of extracting rose essence, unchanged for a century that produces the special type of perfumes that are still in demand today.

by Farzand Ahmed

